

I wasn't sure if this was a LinkedIn or Facebook post to be honest, but considering Robert's profound influence on my professional career - I thought it best to highlight the wonderful impact he had on many aspiring educators, performers, conductors, and friends. I am saddened to hear of his recent passing.

I met Robert Wīremu on my third day (I think, it's been a while!) of my Music degree. Our cohort of first years had been informed that we had a mandatory attendance class early on a Friday morning. I came to find out, to my horror, that this was an ensemble singing practical with all undergraduate Music students, regardless of their major.

The extent of my vocal experience up to this point had been the limited number of chapel services I couldn't get out of, using band practice as an excuse. Thus, I was firmly out of my comfort zone, and frankly very intimidated by the thought of singing in the presence of university level vocal students. I hid behind my saxophone for a reason!

I'm a little embarrassed to say that at the time I resented being required to attend this class. I would sing as quietly as possible, whilst trying to listen to the person next to me for the right notes. The first year of this class was tough for me, and ended with a performance at the School of Music's award night (mandatory attendance, of course) as well as an assessment containing demonstrations of sight-singing and selections of our performance pieces.

This final vocal assessment, or musicianship as the university liked to call it, was one-on-one with a member of teaching staff. I got Robert as my assessor. He could clearly see that I was under-prepared and embarrassed. His kindness, patience, and understanding in this moment forever changed my approach to performance teaching, and my wider education praxis. Robert kindly asked what my instrument was, to which I answered "oh uh...saxophone, but I don't major in performance.", quickly trying to lower his expectations of my ability. He replied "wonderful, we can start there". Robert went on to explain the vowel sounds, using his fantastic Vowel Clock - that I've gone on to use with my own students! He described everything in 'saxophone' terms for me, and then got me to re-attempt my assessment; a minimal pass was achieved.

Robert's gentle approach yet fierce passion for music, and vocal training/performance brought out the best in his students, myself included. My active participation in the cohort choir during my second year was night-and-day to first year; and with it my assessment results. I will admit that I still somewhat lamented our rehearsals, but my fear of attending was greatly diminished.

I will never forget two moments from one of our final rehearsals before COVID and my final assessment with Robert:

The absolute last thing I wanted in this class was to be called on for an answer or to demonstrate anything at all. Yet, notwithstanding great protest, myself and my seat mates were called upon to sing a section of the piece so he could fix our enunciation. He picked at our accents and made each of us say a specific word. He got to me and I said my word, he parroted the word back to me in an exaggerated Kiwi accent. Robert let out a small chuckle and a cheeky grin, and moved on to the next student. Nothing happened, I didn't melt, the world

didn't end. Without being too on the nose, I would liken it to a scene in Mary Poppins with the spoon of medicine. I went in expecting horrible nasty medicine but instead found strawberry ice.

Robert's methodology illustrated the importance of these small actions and their impact on students - with myself having experienced it first-hand!

My final memory I would like to share is that of my final musicianship assessment with Robert. I made my way to the School of Music at 10:15am, looking to be early. I rounded the corner and approached the room to be met by "Ah, Alexander, yes...10:30am, very prompt", I replied "oh Robert, I can wait outside if you'd like", "No no, we will begin with haste" he confirmed. He queried if I was excited to almost be done, I confirmed my elation at the thought of finishing for the semester. Whilst we had the time, I shone a small light on my attitude towards my ability, and the cohort choir. Robert replied that he was happy that I had turned my approach around. The remaining topics of conversation I am strained to remember, there were discussions of us running into each other at the airport and distant relations. What I do remember is the warmth, kindness, and compassion of the scene. A student then appeared outside the window to the practice room, and Robert hastily said "I suppose we should do your assessment now!". I checked my grade after some weeks, the equivalent of a B+.

I never saw or spoke to Robert after this. I am dejected that I never got to share the irony of one of the aspects of my current occupation, Choir Director. As I'm sure he would have had a myriad of jokes and words of advice.

Thank you, Robert.

Alexander